and Company made a reference to ‘unsound concerns’, a member of the committee pointedly asked a leading question, ‘Do you refer to the Tuticorin Swadeshi Co.?’[28] Lieutenant Commander F.H. Cooke, port officer of Calicut, squarely blamed the collapse of Indian shipping companies on their ignorance. In elaborating on this he recalled ‘the one at Tuticorin’, and said they bought two ships of which one was unsuitable and another had broken boilers.[29] His other complaint was the ideology of the promoters: ‘a very strong political bias exist[ed] in the minds of the people who started the new companies. People who knew nothing about ship owning with a good deal of law in their brains I fancy and very little of shipping knowledge entered into the business. When the Tuticorin line was going bankrupt, serious riots broke out in Tuticorin which can be traced to the same people.’ ‘I believe there were political motives in starting the line.’[30]

How did the defunct SSNCo defend itself against these charges?

S.D. Krishna Aiyangar Spars

Luckily, S.D. Krishna Aiyangar, the honorary secretary of the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company was among the witnesses examined by the Indian Mercantile Marine Committee. Why he was chosen, overlooking VOC is not known. Perhaps VOC may have been too hot to handle.

On 17 January 1924, S.D. Krishna Aiyangar appeared before the committee at its Madras sitting. In the absence of Captain Headlam, Arthur H. Froom chaired the session. Headlam’s absence may have been just coincidence. But it seems like a script for a melodramatic Tamil film: nothing else can describe the face-off between BI’s managing partner and the erstwhile helmsman of SSNCo.

Krishna Aiyangar had by then submitted replies to the general questionnaire prepared by the committee and had also appended for good measure a supplementary statement. Having borne the brunt of official hostility and seeing at first hand the liquidation of the company despite Herculean efforts and sacrifices, Krishna Aiyangar pulled few punches.[31] Though presented more than a decade after the SSNCo debacle, even a